

ASHU MEHROTRA

Whether you're looking for a PC that can match the sweater you're wearing right now or one that comes backed by a three-year warranty, the choices available in the market today are numerous. Those days when only large companies or people with relatives abroad bought branded PCs are long gone. We now have a plethora of options in terms of computer manufacturers who have a nationwide presence and offer everything from comprehensive warranties, sales and service outlets, plenty of bundled (and licensed!) software, and innovative designs. More importantly, branded machines offer users the assurance of quality and service, no matter where they are or where they buy the PC from.

In this shootout, we've brought together the biggest computer manufacturers in the country and evaluated them on a number of grounds. The branded PC experience consists of a lot more than just pure performance. The fact that they bundle a licensed operating system and other software, offer after sales services

with comprehensive warranties and have a national presence make the branded PC worth that extra 10-20 per cent in terms of price, as against your standard assembled white box.

For a few rupees less

Looking for a PC with a set of components that will allow you to get your primary applications accomplished, and which also includes features such as multimedia along with communication and networking, and you have only a limited budget?

Well, with prices of components having come down by almost 30-40 per cent over the last year, it's possible to get a machine with reasonable features for less than Rs 35,000. For instance, a CD-ROM drive is available for as low as Rs 2,000 and is a standard peripheral in most machines. Even the lowest priced PC that we received



More Info on

the test process and the products tested. Check out

Mindware

Quake III scores			Normal	High
Nebula Omax Triad	38.1	20		
Zenith P3 Multimedia PC model 1	35.8	19.9		
Vintrom Elixir Celeron 1000	30.2	21.2		
Wipro Voyager 1100	24.4	17.1		
Netkracker Powered Pentium	24.1	16.2		

The top five scorers in *Quake III* among the Budget systems

TEST PROCESS

For a PC to qualify for this comparison test, it had to have a licensed operating software and applications, warranties, offer a specific configuration with a particular model, and have nationwide service and support.

Based on price, we classified the computers as sub-Rs 35,000 (for budget systems), Rs 35,001 to Rs 50,000 (for mid-range systems) and Rs 50,001 and above (for performance systems). These price categorisations also correspond to the needs of different kinds of users. For instance, a budget PC would be preferred by price-conscious users who would like to have a set of components allowing them to get their primary applications accomplished for as low a price as possible. The mid-range systems would appeal to a second set of users who are looking for a combination of performance and price. Since these users are more technology oriented and the major applications are both graphics and processor intensive,

vendors provide a combination of these two to give the best results possible within this price range. The third price category (performance systems) reflects the needs of users who are purely interested in performance and features, and sometimes, simply the brand. Cost is not a criterion for them. In their own words, "Give me the best!" would sound pretty apt.

What's most important in a branded system is the overall package that you get. maximum weightage (50 per cent) was given to system configuration and the overall package. We looked at parameters such as licensed operating system and applications, system configuration, shipping and packaging, manuals/brochures and system restore CDs, and countrywide sales and support.

We evaluated the performance of these systems on various parameters, using two classifications of tests: Real-world and synthetic benchmarks. More weightage was accorded to the real-world

tests as compared to the synthetic benchmarks.

Among the real-world tests, we ran Photoshop 6.0 to test a computer's processor, RAM and hard disk. We also used AudioActive v1.55 for encoding a sample WAV file to an MP3. This test is a very good indication of the real-world power of the processor as audio encoding is highly processor-dependant. To evaluate the graphics performance of the computer, we ran the *Evolva Demo* and *Quake III Arena*.

Among the synthetic benchmarks were Ziff-Davis Content Creation 2000, a test that uses office productivity suites and applications to evaluate a computer's performance; the SiSoft Sandra 2001te, which is an application that runs low-level tests on the various sub-systems of the computer such as the hard disk, processor and RAM; the 3DMark 2001, which is a gaming benchmark that evaluates the performance of the graphics card.